the oppressed. J. Jayalalithaa, who also served as CM, plays a simpering princess, hanging onto MGR's arm for most of the film. But in real life, she went on to command awe and authority as 'Amma', AIADMK leader and MGR's heir. She rose to power as 'Puraitchi Thalaivi' (Leader of the revolution) with a resounding majority, proving that the stereotype of the helpless woman was largely an invention of the patriarchal Tamil film industry—one that she used to expand her reach.

Roles that depict male actors as crusaders of the downtrodden became the mould for many Tamil actors-turned-politicians in the decades to come, including Rajinikanth, Kamal Haasan and Vijay. In the 1971 film *Rickshawkaran*, for which he snaggled a National Film Award, MGR plays a rickshaw puller who simultaneously solves a murder mystery and upholds the rights of the poor. Rajinikanth played an autorickshaw driver in the 1995 film, *Baashsha*, some 14 years before Vijay played an identical character in *Vettaikaaran*. Though Rajinikanth kept testing political waters after *Baashsha*'s release, launching the fan welfare association Rajini Makkal Mandram in 2018, he soon dissolved the group and his political ambitions.

Vijay has admitted how the superstar inspired him to take to acting. So, it's unsurprising that some of his signature on-screen moves—like spinning when he steps into the frame and flips gum into his mouth—seem like a hat tip to Rajinikanth. But Vijay shows no signs of backing out of politics. The social messaging in films such as *Ghilli* (2004), *Thuppakki* (2012), *Mersal* (2017) and *Sarkar* (2018) becomes pronounced with each successive release. While Kamal Haasan's party Makkal Needhi Maiam did not witness the kind of groundswell that Vijay's party Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) did, he managed to synthesise the actor's focus on ideas and ideology.

**Vijay was inspired by Rajinikanth right down to on-screen moves like the spin when he walks into the frame and flips gum into his mouth**

Most significantly, Vijay has engaged with the younger voters. His recent films such as *Master* (2021) address juvenile justice and systemic neglect, highlighting how marginalised youth are shaped by inequalities. None of his films, however, have attacked caste structures like earlier Dravidian-scripted films. In contrast, Udhayanidhi Stalin, the next DMK chief in the making, is seen making a violent statement against Tamil Nadu's pervasive caste system in his 2023 film *Maamannan*. Vijay's films always soften the blow with action and music.

Vijay's latest film, *Jana Nayagan* (People's Leader), has yet to release. But 'Thalapathy Kacheri', a song from the film, which he sings too, carries sharp political messaging that at once appeals to his young voters without making light of issues such as caste and language politics. The multilingual lyrics—"*Aavoo together bhaiya bhaiya/ Jaadi bedham la ledhaiya/ Ningal sneham pol mannil engum/ Annan kandilla ohh chaiyyaa/... Verithanama vibe-av-alaama* (Come together, brother/ There are no caste differences/ There is no love like yours/ That this brother has seen anywhere else on earth/... Let us vibe like crazy"—is written by Tamil anti-caste rapper Arivu. With its vision of syncretic nationhood, it sounds uncannily like a campaign song.

## VIJAY'S VICTORY MARCH

**1992:** First lead role at age 18 in *Naalaiya Theerpu*

**1996:** First big hit *Poove Unakkaga*, establishes him as a romantic hero

**2004:** *Ghilli* becomes a massive hit, first Tamil film to gross over ₹50 crore

**2009:** Launches fan club Vijay Makkal Iyakkam. Now has 15 mn members

**2012:** *Thuppakki* joins ₹100 crore club, his first film to cross the mark

**2024:** Launches political party Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) in Feb.

**2024:** Gets ₹275 crore for final film, *Jana Nayagan*. Says he is retiring, going into politics full-time

**2026:** Leads TVK to victory in assembly poll, single largest party in the state

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